



Shhh... The Show's Starting

A home entertainment system without a good DVD player would be like a soccer match without a football. We've tested 16 players, each with something unique to offer in the realm of digital entertainment. Here's where you get to decide which one is the best for you...

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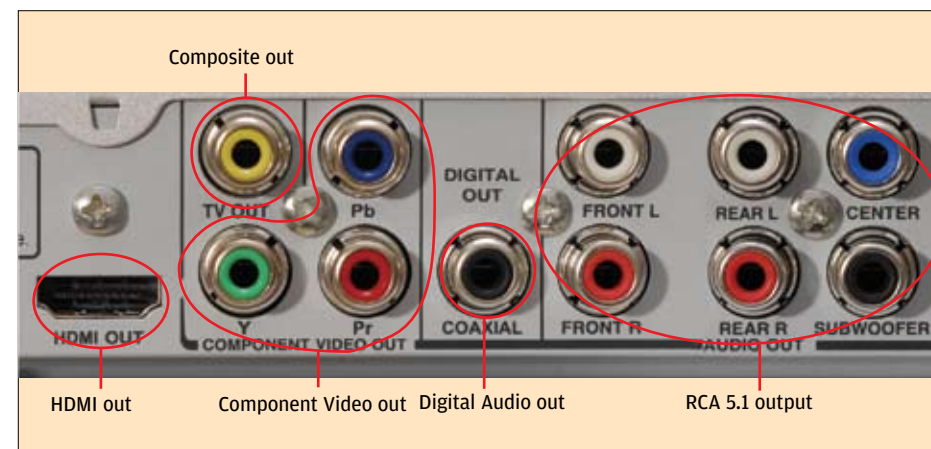
We at *Digit* have always welcomed the domination of digital entertainment. It's a realm where hours are spent in blissful leisure, senses tuned in to the wonderful sights and sounds that only a 50-inch plasma screen coupled with a 500W RMS surround sound system can give you. But wait...besides that 5000:1 contrast ratio screen and that 12-inch subwoofer, aren't you missing something? Unless you intend having your PC in your designer living room (ugh!) you're stuck for a proper source. Simply put—what do you use to

playback all your multimedia content? Well a good DVD player should do the trick. It can't playback all the formats your Winamp / VLC + PC combination can, but it does look a sight more at home in your living room where aesthetics is everything, and space is a premium ill afforded to such eye sores as an ugly beige box.

DVD players, as we call them for lack of a better term (for they are jacks of many formats and not just masters of one) are in fact one of the hottest selling consumer entertainment products, and having a sleek, black / silver box beneath your TV has become a de facto standard now,

up from the status symbol it was years ago during the age of VCRs. DVD players have become the staple of many a movie junkie, and although they can be used for music and photo files as well, their major use was intended as (and is) playback of video. The VCD players of yesteryear have given way to DVD players—these players play dual layer DVD videos, (called DVD 9), as well as VCDs, as well as the more recent DivX and AVI formats. High Definition (HD) resolutions are supported by some players which will also generally have the designation *HD Ready*, *HD Compliant* or such. Although HD formats like TS, MKV and WMV are meant primarily for PCs, even DivX and AVI files can be encoded at HD resolutions like 480p, 720p, 1080i, or 1080p which are the most common resolutions for HD content.

When buying a DVD player, it's very important to also decide on the other components of your entertainment setup so as to maintain a synergy between components. Some DVD players come with bundled surround speaker systems like the Moser Baer MBI AV 780, which had a 5.1 setup bundled. For others, you may have to choose a set of speakers (refer to our speaker test in this issue). You will also have to choose a television,



The rear of your DVD player demystified

while regular 21- and 29-inch CRTs work fine for VCDs, they are unsuitable for viewing widescreen content. Throw in the fact that 95 per cent of all video sources today are widescreen and you have a serious problem of thick black bands appearing on the top and bottom of your CRT TV. Of course, such banding is also common on LCD and Plasma TVs, but it's a lot better considering most of these TVs have aspect ratios of 16:10.

But that's another story for another time, without further ado let's get into the thick of our test. Of the 16 DVD players we tested this month there were two very unique players—the

LG DP271B and the Moser Baer MBI AV 780, both very different beasts but their exclusivity was enough to warrant them to get their own special box.

Non-HDMI Players:

Eleven of our test subjects were of the non-HDMI variety and we'll look at them first. Onida's Candy was one of the funkiest, and definitely the most chic looking player across all categories. A bright red colour theme—*candy* red, if you will—extends to the remote control unit as well as the top body of the player. The unique shape like a half cut cake simply adds to the overall look that Onida has tried hard for—cool, young

How We Tested

We divided our DivX players into the following categories on the basis of the resolution of content playback supported.

1. Native HD resolution players
2. DVD players

Features:

We tested mainly two aspects of features for each player:

1. Connectivity: includes the physical connects present on the player for audio, video and miscellaneous connects
2. Formats supported: includes the codec and format support for audio, video and image files

Performance:

1. **Video Playback:** we played back VCDs, DVDs, and HD content (on players supporting HD) and checked for video quality. We also checked for skipping of frames, colour reproduction, as well as scanning problems. For HD content we used 720p and 1080p clips

2. **Audio Playback:** we checked for audio quality on MP3 playback. Our Test MP3s used were encoded from original SACDs at 320 Kbps at high quality settings

3. **Image Quality:** we used a variety of JPEG files, at different resolutions on our photo CD

4. We also checked the video formats that each player was capable of, in case a format is listed as played, we actually tested to validate this claim

We used a 32-inch 1080p supporting LCD panel from Vu Technologies. Colour, Contrast and Brightness settings on the display were kept constant throughout the test. Progressive Scanning was enabled throughout, as was 5.1 audio. For the Non-HDMI DVD players we used Component as our choice for video, while the HDMI port was used on players supporting it. The Altec Lansing MX5021 was used as our reference for

music, while Logitech's Z5500D was used as while benchmarking videos, 5.1 surround and Dolby DTS 2 were also enabled throughout the video tests.

Audio Test Files:

1. Guns and Roses—*November Rain*
2. Eagles—*Hotel California*
3. Eric Clapton—*Layla*
4. The Corrs—*Brid Og Ni Mhaille*

Video Test Files (Select Scenes):

1. Transformers (DVD 9 and 720p)
2. Star Wars Episode 1: The Phantom Menace (DivX, 1080p)
3. Sahara (DVD 9)
4. Pitch Black (DVD 9)
5. Underworld (DVD 9)
6. Eragon (VCD)

Images:

Various subjects shot at 7.0 megapixels (Canon A710IS) and 10.0 megapixels (Nikon D40x)